

SOCIETY

NAWAB OF THE KEBAB

History, family, tradition. The nation rightly recognises the secretive chef's legacy.

By Moeena Halim

TRACING HIS LINEAGE

QURESHI CLASSICS

FROM THE ARCHIVES
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Society
Nawab of the Kebab

The first chef to win a Padma Shri, in the culinary arts category, the 81-year-old Qureshi compares the kebab, born in the village of Kakori, 15 km from Lucknow, to a Nawab's silk sherwani. And while the country lauds him as the king of dum pukht, the Awadhi art of slow cooking, it is these kebabs he's most proud of. "I once made M.F. Husain 101 kebabs. He tasted them all and said: 'They're all wonderful but the *badshah* is the kakori kebab'," he recalls.

Qureshi has served some of the biggest names in the country and he isn't discreet about it. During a long, languorous lunch, he drops names several times, regaling us with tales of feeding the country's premiers, from Jawaharlal Nehru and his daughter Indira Gandhi to Narendra Modi now.

A state-level wrestler in his Lucknow days, Qureshi is still an imposing figure. He can seem quite intimidating, except that he is generous with the smiles he lets slip from under his thick, white moustache. He is just as generous with sharing time-honoured recipes which he plans to pen down in a book (he's often accused of keeping them secret). "Were it so, how'd the ITC restaurants run?" he asks. There was a time, though, when he carried his recipes in pudiyas, away from the prying eyes of fellow bawarchis.

–by Moeena Halim

THE BIG BUFFET

» **Bukhara made it to several of the World's 50 Best Restaurants lists, putting Indian food on the global culinary map**

» **Melt-in-the-mouth kakori and galouti kebabs became universally popular, as did kaali dal**

» **Tandoori food gained respectability**

» **Indian restaurant cuisine became more refined and showcased regional dishes with confidence**

» **Vegetarian tandoori kebabs crafted with cauliflower, potato, paneer and green bell peppers were crafted in Bukhara. That contribution is immeasurable in its influence**

jewel in chef Imtiaz's crown was the Dum ki Biryani. Chef Imtiaz himself was a loveable extrovert. Grey-haired with handlebar mustachios, he regaled everyone with hints of the aphrodisiacal ingredients in his repertoire."

Bukhara, meanwhile, was spearheaded by Madan Lal Jaiswal, who had been nabbed from Tandoor at the President Hotel on Asaf Ali Road. The show kitchen was put in to change the perception about Indian cookrooms being 'grubby'. Bukhara started as an 18-cover restaurant, serving naan and kebabs, the Sikandari Raan and, of course, the slow-cooked Dal Bukhara, but with a hard rule that no curries would be offered. It became a huge success and expanded into a nearly 140-seater joint. Consistency has held Bukhara in good stead and it's still a pit-stop for international celebrities and heads of state visiting Delhi.

₹3,950

each for the Sikandari Raan and Tandoori Jhinga, the most expensive dishes at Bukhara

DID YOU KNOW?

The entire Clinton family—Bill, Hillary and Chelsea—had platters named after themselves at Bukhara

Both restaurants have had a huge influence on the HoReCa (hotel, restaurant and cafe) industry, with dishes and techniques being adopted across the board, and regional cuisines getting their due.

Bukhara's success encouraged ITC to open franchises abroad, from Hong Kong to Bahrain, Montreal to Singapore, but they all shut eventually. "We were too early in America. People didn't think Indian food could be had without curry and rice," says Anand. "Also, we used goat, but, in those days, you would only get sheep abroad." There's only one Bukhara now, at the ITC Maurya. ITC does have the Peshawri chain across their hotels, with the same decor and menu, but allowing for 20 per cent customisation in each location.

While the popularity of Bukhara and Dum Pukht remains undiminished, ITC's own Indian culinary repertoire has expanded to Royal Vega—serving dishes "based on the ancient Indian system of seasonal cooking"—and Avartana, which offers progressive South Indian fare. ■